

IN PROFILE

Frank Bridge

Britten's teacher, Frank Bridge (1879–1941), was a professional viola player before establishing a reputation as a composer with works such as the orchestral tone poem *The Sea* (1911), which so impressed Britten as a child. Partly in response to the horrors of World War I, Bridge later adopted an astringent Modernist style that estranged many of his earlier admirers. His powerful work for cello and orchestra, *Oration, Concerto Elegiaco* (1930), was specifically intended as an anti-war protest. Bridge's key advice to the young Britten was that "you should find yourself and be true to what you found."

Edward Benjamin Britten was born in 1913 in Lowestoft, on the east coast of England. His father, a dentist, was indifferent to music, but his mother was an amateur musician, delighted to find in Benjamin a son who shared her tastes. He was sent to private schools that did nothing to encourage music, but at home he learned to play the piano and the viola. At the age of 12, he expressed enthusiasm for an orchestral piece by British composer Frank Bridge, heard at a concert. Through personal contacts his mother arranged for him to have composition lessons with Bridge, who became his musical mentor.